CEDAR-MAPLE BAKED BEANS

serves 8

At Owamni, I make a version of these baked beans with many Indigenous varieties. While most lima beans grow best in warm climates, the Potawatomi people in Wisconsin adapted this variety of lima bean, known as the Potawatomi pole bean, to grow well in our region. Over generations, they kept it safe so we can still enjoy it today, and I love these big, flat beans in this dish.

Maple gives these baked beans that characteristic sweetness, but the addition of cedar (or you can substitute with balsam fir) gives them a beautiful, unexpected aroma. Growing up, we traditionally boiled cedar to help purify the air and to drink for tea. It's high in vitamin C, so popular during cold season. While it's safe to ingest in smaller quantities like this, it's a powerful plant and best not to consume every day. Many people also recommend avoiding it when pregnant.

- 2 tablespoons sunflower oil
- 1 large yellow onion, chopped
- Fine sea salt
- 2 cups dried Potawatomi Pole Lima Beans or other multicolored lima beans, soaked overnight, drained, and well rinsed
- ¾ cup maple syrup
- 1 (5-inch) piece fresh or dried northern white cedar, balsam fir, or other edible conifers (see Notes), plus a small piece or a few needles, for garnish

Preheat the oven to 300°F.

In a large Dutch oven, heat the oil over medium heat. Add the onion and 1 teaspoon salt and cook for 6 to 8 minutes, stirring, until the onion is translucent. Add the beans, 4 cups water, the syrup, and ½ teaspoon fine sea salt and bring to a simmer. Arrange the cedar piece on top.

Cover, transfer the beans to the oven, and bake for 30 minutes. Uncover and stir and continue to cook the beans, uncovered, until tender. They should take between 1 hour 30 minutes and 2 hours total to cook. If the water level falls below the beans before they're tender, add just enough water to cover. Ultimately, you want beans that are tender and suspended in a small amount of liquid.

Remove the cedar piece. Taste and season with more salt, as needed. Finely chop a little bit of fresh cedar to sprinkle on top and serve.

The baked beans can be refrigerated in their liquid overnight. Reheat gently over low heat.

Notes

- *I like to soak the beans before I cook them because they cook more evenly this way, so be sure to plan ahead.*
- *Northern white cedar and balsam fir grow prolifically in the Great Lakes, and I can usually harvest from both trees either in my own backyard or with a walk around my neighborhood. See Conifers, page 22, for more about sourcing conifers for cooking.*
- *This recipe is completely plant-based, but if you'd like to enrich the flavor of the bean cooking liquid, you could add shredded smoked turkey during the last 30 minutes of cooking, when the beans are nearly tender.*